

of Net Neutrality and characterises the original definition as a 'puritan view'.

So what exactly is available on FreeBasics? Facebook maintains that any service that abides by their technical specifications can come onto the FreeBasics platform. At the time of writing this, there are currently 31 services across a narrow array of genres which include genuinely helpful ones like Wikipedia, wikiHow, AccuWeather, job search portals and few news portals.

Then there are questionable ones like a service that dishes out Astrological advice. Previously, there was even a real estate portal as part of the small bouquet of services. Why questionable? How is a service that is supposed to bring the internet to those who cannot afford data packs in the first place be able to afford housing? The real estate service is no longer part of FreeBasics. But we must wonder where exactly these services come into play towards enriching the lives of the poor when Mark Zuckerberg said, "And in the 21st century, everyone also deserves access to the tools and information that can help them to achieve all those other public services, and all their fundamental social and economic rights."

That's why everyone also deserves access to free basic internet services". Free ... basic ...

Quite a few partners have already quit FreeBasics in the midst of the massive backlash Internet.org received last year. ClearTrip, the online travel company, had this to say, "So while our original intent was noble, it is impossible to pretend there is no conflict of interest (both real and perceived) in our decision to be a participant in Internet.org". And just as this article was being written, Google who'd been a partner since the launch of Internet.org quit the platform. Google has declined to comment on the rationale behind this move but a large entity like Google quitting a platform only raises more questions.

'ENRICHING' THE LIVES OF THE POOR

Quite a few of the services on FreeBasics that benefit the poor are already in place through various government grassroots programmes so the issue then becomes that of convenience of getting the same information in the palm of your hand

rather than travelling, say a few kilometers, to the nearest government office. However, knowledge without proper education to interpret the same is a dangerous issue. Especially, when it comes to issues like child care. Which is why it is always advisable to avail the services of a trained personnel rather than resorting to self medication. And one of the reasons why government programmes succeed is that you need the right information and a guiding hand to coax the underprivileged. Let us throw in the age-old analogy of teaching a man to fish versus giving it to him. FreeBasics is akin to showing a starving man just the photo of a fish and telling him it's edible.

FOOTING THE BILL

No device is ever free and we all know that. So the contention is that any TSP (Telecommunications Service Provider) that partners with Facebook – Reliance in this case – has to spend a significant amount towards setting up the infrastructure required to make space for an additional one billion Indian who don't have access to it. Our contention is that TSPs are going to spend that money either ways just to cater to our organic growth. Add to this, the fact that the services on FreeBasics are going to be heavily stripped down to reduce the data footprint. And that there will be a contention ratio put in place, which for consumers is set to a minimum of 1:50 by TRAI for broadband consumers. Since Free Basics is even more data efficient, it could end up being much lower. Essentially, TSPs will not have to spend an awful lot to build the infrastructure. One of the major expenditures we foresee is that infrastructure will have to be built in rural areas which aren't prime for high bandwidth consumption and subsequently, revenue from rural areas will be lower.

But Facebook in its anniversary report mentioned that 50 per cent of the customers using Free Basics subscribed to a paid plan after the very first month.

Essentially, Reliance will have to foot the bill for half the customers after one month. Whether the other half continues to be on the platform was not revealed. And this pattern was observed in the

many other countries that Free Basics currently exists excluding India. So is one half paying for the whole enough to sustain the infrastructure growth? If we go by profitability of telecom companies, the answer is probably yes. Since Facebook has claimed that half the users to indeed pay, it isn't exactly an experiment for Indian telcos. They're not going to burn their fingers since they do have a pretty good idea about the outcome.

NO ADS? SO HOW WILL THEY MAKE MONEY?

Facebook has mentioned that there will be no advertisements on Free Basics but it hasn't mentioned whether this model will be followed forever or if it is 'subject to change'. But companies change service agreements whenever greed takes over or if it is actually necessitated to ensure the survival of the company.

What makes us skeptical of Facebook's intentions is because of what VP of Internet.org, Chris Daniels said in an AMA (Ask Me Anything) on Reddit –



"While we haven't found any business model where ad revenue could pay for people's access to the internet (look at Facebook's revenue, its far, far less than revenue operators receive from data charges), if there is a way that we can do so, then we want to be able to explore that in the future".

This comes from the company that posted a growth in advertising revenue by 53 per cent in the UK with 70 per cent of that share coming from mobile ad sales. If we are to take another example, the advertising giant, Google, earned over a billion dollars in ad revenue from the Indian market and they themselves said that Facebook's Free Basics program of getting TSPs to pay for the bandwidth, if implemented will be a game changer.

So why exactly is Facebook saying that mobile ad revenue cannot sustain the Free Basics system?